which was exposed in February 2013 by the Mandiant Corporation.[29] Everything from purses and CDs to solar panels and software has been illegally copied by the Chinese, who have taken petabytes of information illegally over the past decade. Similarly, official Chinese policies such as "indigenous innovation" are meant to transfer intellectual property from Western businesses to their Chinese partners, some of which are government owned.[30] The world may never fully know the degree to which America and other advanced nations unknowingly subsidized the growth of the Chinese economy.

Nor does Chinese spying stop at consumer goods and trade secrets; rather, it is employed as a primary tool of Chinese statecraft. Beijing spies in sweeping, indiscriminate ways on a broad range of American interests and citizens. In 2015, it was revealed that Chinese hackers stole from the US government the confidential personal information of more than 22 million Americans, many of whom held security clearances, as well as their spouses and family members.[31] At the same time, newspapers reported that Chinese actors were breaking into private corporations such as insurance companies, further stealing information on millions of Americans, all with the goal of building massive databases to identify potential targets of blackmail.[32] Seemingly good-faith aid by the Chinese government also can hide espionage activities. After Beijing financed and built the new African Union's headquarters in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, in 2012, the building's computer servers sent sensitive data to Shanghai every night, while hidden microphones were discovered in subsequent security sweeps.[33]

China's recent telecommunications dominance raises fears of sophisticated espionage operations against private companies and individuals, as well as governments. Although it has become the world's largest telecom systems provider, Huawei has long been dogged by allegations of hidden backdoors and sloppy security protocols in its systems, which can lead to the planned or inadvertent siphoning off of data from users of Huawei equipment.[34] Huawei and other Chinese telecoms firms also undermine good governance and gain support of corrupt elites, particularly in developing areas of the world. For example,